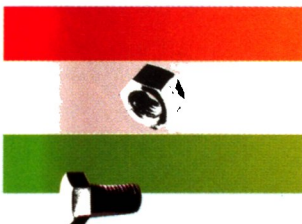


ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

Republic of Nutters



It was an alarming sight and possible only in India. There was BJP MLA Madhu Srivastava, best known for celebrating Holi by firing indiscriminately, greeting passengers of the Mumbai-bound Jammu Tawi Express with a wide smile, hoping to convey a "message of peace" to MNS chief Raj Thackeray. Only in India would one oddball think he could put down another oddball with some Gandhigiri. Between an ayurvedic doctor who worships his rabble-rousing daughter, Sadhvi Pragya Singh Thakur, and a twitch-a-minute politician's son, Rahul Mahajan, who leans openly at a former convict, Monica Bedi, every night on national television, India is in danger of becoming a republic of nutters. Thanks to news tv that has raised the bar on craziness, we are now awash in all manner of cranks. There's Anbumani Ramadoss who finds a new thing to ban or un-ban every 15 minutes; Mamata Banerjee who can scream a multinational corporation out of existence from a state; and Vaiko who likes to spend time in jail for an extra-territorial cause. Sometimes I'm tempted to take out my witch's hat and portable cauldron to keep them company. But it makes me a tad nostalgic. Time was



SAURABH SINGH

when we had only a Morarji Desai with his urine drinking and Raj Narain with his cow-rearing to laugh at. They were God's gifts to newspaper people, put on earth to divert us from socialism's shortages. But now everywhere you turn weirdness has evolved into a separate art form, and worse, is beginning to be taken seriously. I don't mind the lot in the *Bigg Boss* cast, from Raja Chaudhury, last witnessed on national tv having a drunken meltdown, to the distracted dhaba owner Ashutosh whose ideas about women are better accompanied with a bovine grunt. They're toxic only to each other, and are following in the celebrity-seeking footsteps of Mika and Rakhi Sawant. And I certainly don't mind *The White Tiger's* weirdo hero, Balram Halwai, who writes long letters to the Chinese premier and murders his boss. He does, after all, show us a side of India we have been blinded to. No, my worry is that as a nation we have become remarkably tolerant of people who rant, rave and unravel. Of people who want to snatch livelihoods and take away homes. I don't mind so much if we become Hick Town, Midwest America, where giantesses on daytime tv will hold forth on abusive parents and cheating husbands. What I worry about is becoming a bunch of dangerous loonies who wear white sheets, carry flaming torches and hunt down innocent people. Scary.



B K RAMESH

No Speed Limits

BANGALORE There couldn't have been a better Diwali gift for the five lakh-odd truckers in Karnataka. The state Government has finally decided to apply its brakes on the plan to make it compulsory for trucks to be fitted with speed governors. The plan caused truckers to take their vehicles off the road twice since 2004. In February, following the truckers strike, owners of nearly 15,000 cabs, mainly serving the information technology industry, appealed to the Government to exempt them from using the device. Karnataka

Truckers' Association chief G.R. Shanmugappa wants the state Government to brief transport authorities in Delhi and appeal against a state high court directive in this regard. State Transport Minister R. Ashok says the Centre did not respond to his Government's letters. He defended the decision stating that Karnataka could neither afford another strike nor lose precious revenues due to truckers registering their vehicles in states who do not have this rule. There is no uniform rule for speed governors in India. **by Stephen David**

Spot the Nonchalance

DELHI In the space of two days a leopard has mauled five people in Vejagaon village in Chandrapur district of Maharashtra, two of the victims succumbing to injuries. Despite the alarming attacks, the Forest Department has sent just a solitary cage to nab the predator and has posted two unarmed

guards in the village. Chandrapur has a high leopard and tiger population. Janakpur and Talodhi were the earlier flash-points in the district where tigers had caused havoc by killing many. In the last couple of years, there have been 40 predator-related deaths in Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve. This year 13 people have been killed so far. The villagers blame the lackadaisical Forest Department for their woes.

by Mihir Srivastava